

THE KANE ACADEMY · FREE GUIDE FOR PARENTS

THE PRE-SEASON & TRYOUT BLUEPRINT

for parents of basketball players

The 10 things well-meaning parents do during tryout season that quietly cost their child confidence — and exactly what to say instead, in the three windows that decide how he walks into that gym.

BY COACH DENNIS KANE

440 WINS · CIF CHAMPION · 1,000+ PARENT CONVERSATIONS · 12 PROS · 71 COLLEGE PLAYERS
AND A DEVELOPMENT PLAN FOR YOU AND YOUR KID

Read this before the first tryout.

START HERE

TRYOUTS DON'T TEST YOUR CHILD. THEY TEST THE ENVIRONMENT AROUND HIM.

After 440 wins and 1,000+ parent conversations, I have watched thousands of kids walk into a tryout gym. The ones who compete freely and the ones who play not to make a mistake are almost never separated by skill. They're separated by what happened in the car, at dinner, and in the doorway on the way out.

Every parent I've coached wanted their child to succeed. That has never been the problem. The damage in tryout season comes from good intentions delivered at the worst possible moment — a pep talk that lands as pressure, a question that asks for a verdict, a silence that reads as disappointment.

Tryouts compress everything. A season gives a kid twenty chances to show you who he is. A tryout gives him three days. That compression is why the ordinary things you say all year hit so much harder right now.

WHAT THIS GUIDE IS

Ten mistakes, with the exact replacement line for each. Then the three windows — the week before, the tryout itself, and the 48 hours after the list goes up — and what your job actually is in each one.

Read it slowly. Most parents find one habit in here that changes the whole season.

Talent determines what your child *can* do. What surrounds him determines what he's willing to try. That's the part you control, and it's the whole reason this guide exists.

10 MISTAKES THAT COST CONFIDENCE

None of these come from a bad parent. All ten come from a parent trying to help at a moment when helping isn't the job.

1 THE PARKING-LOT PEP TALK

"Today's the day. Go prove yourself." You mean it as fuel. He hears that the next two hours decide who he is.

✓ "You've already put in the work. Go compete and have fun."

2 SCOUTING THE GYM OUT LOUD

Counting the other kids, sizing up who's tall, naming who made it last year. You're teaching him to measure himself against the room instead of against the rep in front of him.

✓ Say nothing about anyone else in the building.

3 COACHING FROM THE BLEACHERS

Tryouts are an evaluation, and a coach watching your child glance at you after every possession is watching a kid who isn't free.

✓ Sit where he can't find you. Clap for the whole floor.

4 ASKING "HOW DID YOU DO?"

It asks for a verdict he isn't qualified to give and hasn't been told yet. He'll guess, and he'll usually guess low.

✓ "What did you compete hardest at today?"

5 APPROACHING THE COACH MID-TRYOUT

Anything you say during an evaluation window reads as lobbying, and it attaches your name to his.

✓ Wait. If there's a conversation to have, it happens after the list, in private.

10 MISTAKES THAT COST CONFIDENCE

6 COMPARING HIS TRYOUT TO ANOTHER KID'S

"Jaden looked slow out there." It feels like reassurance. It teaches him that his standing depends on someone else's bad day.

- ✓ Compare him only to his own tape from last season.

7 TREATING THE LIST AS A VERDICT ON THE KID

A roster is a coach's read of a fit, on one week, for one team. Your reaction is what turns it into a statement about his worth.

- ✓ Separate the outcome from the identity, out loud, in the first minute.

8 BLAMING THE COACH WHEN IT DOESN'T GO HIS WAY

It feels loyal. What it teaches is that outcomes are decided by other people — which is the foundation of every excuse he'll make for the next ten years.

- ✓ "What do you think he was looking for that we can go build?"

9 FIXING IT FOR HIM

The email, the phone call, the conversation you have on his behalf. The adversity was the curriculum. Removing it removes the lesson.

- ✓ If a question needs asking, he asks it. You drive.

10 GOING QUIET

The silent car, the shortened dinner, the warmth that doesn't come back until the next good day. Kids read withdrawal faster than criticism.

- ✓ Same voice, same warmth, same night. Especially that night.

THE THREE WINDOWS THAT DECIDE IT

Removing pressure isn't enough on its own. You have to put something steady in its place. Here is what your job is in each window — and just as importantly, what it isn't.

WINDOW ONE — THE WEEK BEFORE

Your job: lower the stakes without lowering the standard.

- Ask once, early: “What's one thing you want to show them?” Then leave it alone.
- No new training program, no cram sessions. Nothing built in one week shows up in that gym.
- Protect sleep and food harder than you protect gym time.
- Don't rehearse outcomes out loud — not making it, making it, which team. He's already running those.
- Mute the three accounts that make you anxious about where he should be by now.

WINDOW TWO — TRYOUT DAY

Your job: be boring, warm, and unreadable.

- Arrive early. Rushed is a mood he carries onto the floor.
- In the doorway: “Go compete. I love watching you play.” That's the whole speech.
- Sit where he can't easily find you, and away from the loudest parents in the gym.
- Clap for the floor. Not just for him, and never at a coach.
- Stay flat on mistakes. Your face after a turnover is the only scouting report he's reading.

WINDOW THREE — THE FIRST EIGHT SECONDS AFTER

Your job: say almost nothing, and mean it.

- Pause. Smile first — before any words.
- Then one of: “I loved watching you compete.” · “You worked hard out there.” · “How did it feel?”
- Then stop. If he wants to talk, he will. If he doesn't, that's information, not rejection.
- No technical feedback for 24 hours. Not one note, however gently you'd deliver it.

WHEN THE LIST DOESN'T HAVE HIS NAME ON IT

This is the moment parents ask me about more than any other, and it's the one most of them handle backwards — not out of carelessness, but because watching your child hurt makes you want to do something, and almost everything there is to do makes it worse.

THE FIRST HOUR — SAY THIS

"I'm sorry. That one hurts."

"I'm proud of you for putting yourself out there."

"Nothing about today changes anything between us."

Then stop. Don't explain the decision, don't diagnose it, don't promise it'll be different next year. He isn't ready to hear any of it and none of it is the thing he needs in that hour.

THE FOUR THINGS NOT TO DO

Don't blame the coach. It feels like loyalty. What it teaches is that his outcomes belong to other people, and that's the seed of every excuse he'll make for the next decade.

Don't make the call. If there's a question worth asking, he asks it — a few days later, in private. You drive him there.

Don't go quiet. Withdrawal of warmth is read as a verdict. Same voice, same dinner, same night.

Don't immediately go shopping for another team. Rescuing him from the disappointment removes the only part of this with any value in it.

Then, after a week — not before — there's one question worth having him ask the coach: *"What do I need to work on to be considered next time?"* Write the answer down. Work on that specific thing, and only that thing, for a defined stretch. Confidence doesn't come back because you told him he's good. It comes back because he got measurably better at the thing he was told he was missing.

WHY THIS WORKS

- ✓ It's built on what actually separates kids in a tryout gym — not skill, but whether they're competing freely or playing to avoid a mistake.
- ✓ Every replacement line here has been used, by real parents, in real gyms, across 44 years and more than a thousand parent conversations.
- ✓ It removes the pressure points and replaces them with something stable, instead of just telling you what not to do.
- ✓ Most parents see a difference within two or three sessions — usually in how their child talks on the ride home.
- ✓ It's the same approach behind the players I've sent to college and pro basketball — and, more importantly, behind the ones who became good adults.
- ✓ Parents tell me this is the part that saved the relationship, not just the season.

ONE LAST THING

Your child will forget most of what happens at this tryout. He will not forget what your face looked like when he came off the floor, or what the car felt like on the way home.

That part is entirely yours. It's also the part that's still working on him twenty years from now.

YOUR NEXT STEP

THE FULL SYSTEM BEHIND THIS GUIDE

This guide covers tryout week. But the habits that shape your kid do not stop when the list goes up. They show up in every car ride, every bad game, and every hard talk with a coach, all season long.

As a head coach, my high school teams won 440 games. Twelve of my players went on to play pro. Seventy one played in college. The same things that win games build good men. Mental toughness. Confidence. Resilience. They are built on the court and at home.

The Kane Parental System gives you my frameworks for building all three.

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